

WAR GAME Indian Navy ships conduct an exercise with America's USS Nimitz carrier strike group near the Andaman & Nicobar Islands in July 2020

reporting to a single CDS. However, the islands are thinly defended, with few radars or surface to air missile launchers and poor infrastructure.

India's military use of the A&N Islands is a study in contrast to what other great powers have done. The US base on Diego Garcia, an island fortress in the Indian Ocean just south of the Equator, has a 3.6 km runway, bases ships and can launch heavy bombers across Asia. Over the past decade, China has dumped millions of acres of sand onto reefs in the South China Sea to build several mini Diego Garcias—small patches of reclaimed land bristling with missile sites, airfields and docking facilities—and has been using them to reinforce its claim over the entire South China Sea.

In the past five years, New Delhi has been pushing to realise the economic potential of the A&N Islands. They straddle critical sea routes in southeast and east Asia—these include Duncan's Passage, the Ten Degree channel, the Preparis and the Six Degree channel. In 2017, Rs 10,000 crore worth of potential development projects were identified. The government says it has added over 100 km of roads on these islands between 2014 and 2018. Inaugurating the first submarine optic cable to the islands in 2020, PM Modi said they would be the fulcrum of India's blue ocean strategy.

Turning the A&N Islands into unsinkable aircraft carriers will require tens of thousands of crores for radars, missiles, airfields, docks and more

However, building military infrastructure on the islands, over a thousand kilometres from the Indian mainland, will not be easy. Creating "unsinkable aircraft carriers" requires massive investment and several years of sustained infrastructure development. It will need tens of thousands of crores for radars and missiles, maintenance and repair facilities, runways for permanently-based fighters and long range maritime patrol aircraft, coastal defence missiles and more dock berths for warships, patrol craft and submarines.

In early 2014, when the Indian Navy deployed long-range patrol aircraft to search for MH370, the Malaysia Airlines flight that went missing that year, it found its sorties limited by the fuel supplies on the island. The tri-services command, which war-gamed military operations from the island, found glaring logistics and infrastructure shortfalls. Most vulnerabilities remain classified, but can be inferred as including limited quantities of fuel for aircraft and warships. The Su-30MKI, a heavy fighter with a range of 3,000 km, is an ideal fighter to be based on the islands. Each Su-30MKI, however, needs 12,000 litres of aviation fuel for a four-hour sortie. Both Port Blair and Car Nicobar lack twin runways (to ensure redundancy in case one is disabled). A new IAF airfield to operate fighter aircraft on the southernmost island, Great Nicobar, is yet to materialise. Since military deployments are not only about presence but also about sustenance, the armed forces will have to build large underground fuel storage tanks that will allow fighter jets to conduct more combat sorties. Freshwater desalination plants will also be needed to supply the increase in personnel. "One-off interventions from the mainland apart, the question remains—can we maintain and operate Su-30s from the Andaman Islands for prolonged deployments?" asks a retired admiral who did not want to be named. Issues like these mean the islands remain peacetime staging posts rather than permanent bases. US military historian Edward Luttwak recommends India leverage the potential of shore-based aircraft rather than aircraft carriers that are WWII relics. Delivering the MP-IDSA's annual K. Subrahmanyam memorial lecture on February 3, he said: "The Indian Navy spends all its money on an aircraft carrier—when I look at the map, India is an aircraft carrier. The navy should be empowered to buy aircraft all along India, the Andaman & Nicobar Islands... and dominate the entry to the Persian Gulf, the Suez Canal, the Straits of Malacca with multiple missiles and aircraft that cost about the [same as] a single aircraft carrier, which is vulnerable and has a limited number of combat aircraft."

"There are infrastructure issues, but they can be addressed," says defence analyst Rear Admiral Sudarshan Shrikhande. "Mobile batteries like Brahmos would be very useful and less vulnerable. The islands would be useful for their dispersed air and missile launch potential as well as for Intelligence Surveillance and Reconnaissance (ISR). There may be new complications, as there have always been for any epoch of warfare." While the existing issues will take time to solve, the larger question of whether the A&N Islands can become significant military bases within this decade remains yet unanswered. ■